

BERNERA NEWS

A Community Newsletter 
in association with

BERNERA BRIDGE UPDATE

Statement from Comhairle nan Eilean Siar 14th January 2021

Well, here we are at the start of a New Year. All of us, I am sure, are hoping that life slowly starts to return to normal after such a difficult time with coronavirus restrictions during 2020, yet still aware that we've got a long way to go before that is likely.

In the meantime I hope that we continue to pull together as a Community, supporting those more vulnerable than ourselves, and watching out for our neighbours and friends.

Sadly, the Bernera Community starts the year with a number of bereavements. We at the Bernera News would like to express our condolences to all of those affected recently.

Although funerals are yet one more thing to have been changed by the virus restrictions, the Bernera community have ensured that each passing has not gone unnoticed and unmarked. The simple act of members of the Community venturing out to pay their respects in a safe and permitted manner has, I am sure, meant a great deal to those grieving.

We hope, in future editions, to provide suitable memoriam pieces for all those who have passed of late.

Contact us at: 01851 600 159
Text/Whatsapp: 07958 549784
Email: hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk
Or visit us online at:
www.thedailyceilidh.co.uk

Detailed design work is progressing on the Bernera Bridge. Local engineers are working with the bridge supplier on the "launch" requirements, which is basically the procedure and mechanics of pushing the structure from one side to the other.

At the present time the previously quoted timescales appear achievable and no delays are foreseen.

Comhairle officers have been discussing requirements with residents who may be affected by the current weight restrictions, and assisting where practical.

The Comhairle appreciates the patience of the local community at this time.

CHRISTINA MORRISON

We are thoroughly saddened when we realise that our late friend and one time colleague at Bernera School, Christina Morrison, is no longer with us. She passed away recently, at the age of 51, following a short illness; her passing at far too early an age, leaves a very empty place, not only in her own family but with everyone who knew her.

Christina worked for several years in the late 1990s and up to 2002, in the office at Bernera School, where she competently dealt with the paperwork, taking that burden off the headteacher's shoulders, she was exceptionally helpful to all the staff and very easy for us all to work with. She also had supervisory duties in the playground, where she was very good with the children, getting on well with them all but taking no nonsense.

Christina was the eldest member of the family of four of Angus Kenneth and Elma Morrison of 3 Valtos, Uig, and was a Bernera person at heart, choosing to live there at Dun Innes, where she will be remembered as a good neighbour, always willing to help others.

At this very difficult time, we extend our heartfelt sympathy to her mother, Elma, in Stornoway, to her sister, Cathie, her brothers, DC and Angus and to the wider family circle who mourn her passing.

I Macdonald and A Mackinnon.

CORONAVIRUS UPDATE

The Western Isles is currently under Tier 3 of the Scottish Coronavirus Restrictions. The key points of these restrictions are:

You should not meet anyone who is not in your household indoors in your home or in their home. You can meet one other household indoors in a public place such as a café or restaurant. The maximum number of people who can meet indoors in a public (not a home) place is 6 which can be from up to 2 separate households.

You can meet people from other households outdoors in a private garden or in a public place such as a park or an outdoor area of a pub. The maximum number of people who can meet outdoors is 6 which can be from up to 2 separate households.

You must not travel into or out of Level 3 and 4 local authority areas except for essential reasons.

With more restrictions in place, particularly those limiting social contact, it is completely understandable that many people are struggling once more. If you don't feel able to talk to someone that you know, but would like some support please don't ever be afraid to reach out. All of the following organisations offer free, confidential help and support.

Samaritans 116 123
Anxiety UK 0344 775 774
Mind 0300 123 3393
Calm 0800 58 58 58
Crisis text line - text 85258
Child line - 0800 11 11

NHS WESTERN ISLES

Whilst numbers of infection are currently fairly low on Lewis, the national positions, and the new cluster on Barra, sadly give much cause for concern. We must do all that we can to prevent the virus taking a hold in our community.

Please avoid all unnecessary contact with others and remember **FACTS**

Face coverings

Avoid crowded places

Clean your hands & hard surfaces regularly

Two metre distance

Self isolate and book a test if you develop any symptoms.

Please also avoid, where possible, travel to or from the mainland.

Symptoms

The most common symptoms of Covid-19 are:

A high temperature (37.8C or greater)

And / or a new and continuous cough

And / or a loss or change in your sense of smell and / or taste

If you are experiencing any of the above symptoms you and your household should immediately self isolate and book a test by calling **01851 601151** (Mon to Fri 9am - 5.30pm)..



VACCINATION

A Vaccination program is now underway throughout the Western Isles. There are strict eligibility protocols in place to ensure those most at risk of severe Covid-19 are vaccinated first. When you are eligible you will be invited.

There's no need to do anything until you're invited. You do not need to call your GP practice.

Sadly a number of scams are targeting those waiting for their vaccinations. It is therefore important to remember that the Covid-19 vaccine will always be available free of charge. The NHS will never ask you to share bank details to confirm your identity. If you receive a phone call, visit, or letter that you believe to be suspicious please alert the Police and do not give out any personal details.

WINTER FUEL PAYMENT

There have been some issues across the UK with Winter Fuel Payments this year. It seems that the system is not recognising some people who are eligible for the payment.

If you have not received your Winter Fuel Payment you will need to contact the **DWP on 0800 731 0160**

BERNERA POST OFFICE AND SHOP

Although the post office and shop are currently for sale, Aileen and her team would like to assure us all that the Post Office is **open**, and will stay open until a sale is completed.

However, in the meantime, they will 'wind down' the things that they stock on the grocery 'shop' side. Please note that they will continue to stock milk, bread, chilled items, ice cream, hot drinks, snacks and alcohol, as well as some frozen items.

BERNERA SURGERY

Please note that medication should be collected on the following days and times:

Mondays 2.30pm - 5pm | Wednesdays 1.30pm - 4pm | Fridays 11am - 12 noon

All other enquiries should go through Langabhat on **01851 860222**. Please be patient with all staff, they are working hard in difficult times to do their best for you.

BERNERA PETROL PUMP UPDATE

The BCA have commissioned the replacement petrol pump and refilling of the tanks as well as a small cabin to house the supporting services.

This week planning permission was granted for the cabin and works will commence next week to ensure that each necessary part of the process is completed in time for the next.

A concrete pad will be laid next week and the electricity supply has been ordered. Other services will follow and they will keep us updated.



SANTA' S VISIT

The children of Bernera who'd gathered at the playpark on the crisp, cold morning of Saturday 19 December certainly weren't expecting Santa to turn up on a bicycle with a sack full of goodies! Some of the local residents had donned their craft and baking hats and put together a selection of small gifts, such as homemade gingerbread and fudge, kiln-fired Christmas tree ornaments, toys and handmade jewellery, as well as some fruit and seeds for planting, and all presented in an exquisite home-sewn goody bag.



Needless to say, most of the edible gifts were gone in a jiffy, but the longer-lasting ones will surely provide a reminder of the moment for some time to come. We hope all the Bernera kids had a very enjoyable Christmas!

BERNERA BAKES... COCONUT LEMON LOAF

Ingredients:

16oz self raising flour
16oz margarine
16oz caster sugar
4oz coconut
2 lemon rind, grated
8 eggs
4 tbps milk

Topping:

8 tbsps caster sugar
Juice of 2 lemons
Coconut for sprinkling

Method:

Heat oven to 180°C/350°F.
Grease 2lb loaf tin.
Sift all dry ingredients together, add margarine (cut into small pieces).
Rub margarine between fingertips until mixture resembles breadcrumbs.
Add beaten eggs, lemon rind & milk, mixing well.
Spoon mixture into prepared tin and smooth level.
Bake for 45 mins until golden brown & firm to touch.

Cool in tin for 5 minutes, before turning out.

Mix together the lemon juice & caster sugar, spooning over the cake allowing it to soak in before sprinkling with coconut.



Careen MacLennan
Kirkibost

POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - STAYING SANE DURING LOCKDOWN

Last year, I was lucky enough to be able to attend socially-distanced glass classes with two other people. I love art and craft activities – even if all my friends and family end up with examples of my attempts for birthdays and Christmas presents.

I particularly loved doing the glass sessions at Coll Pottery. I still have no idea about how glass reacts or which glass should go with which for that matter, but I remain excited at the outcome. It's always a surprise when my efforts come out of the kiln. Some of my



glass masterpieces had big bubbles in them and some were a different colour from what I saw 'in the raw'. When they were presented to me as the end product, they all looked fabulous as far as I'm concerned. Beautiful

colours, sparkly bits shining in some of the pieces and a real 'pick-me-up' during dowdy times. So, when isolation days are over, you are welcome to come over and admire them all. As you can tell, there'll be no false modesty on my part!



Virginia Allum
Earshader



THE STORY OF THE BERNERA RIOT - PART 1

For centuries the Bernera Crofters had the grazing rights and their summer shielings on the moor at Beann a Chuailean, stretching from the Uig road to the shores of Loch Langabhat and Coirgerod.

In 1872, after sporting estates had been established at Morsgail and Scaliscro, this land was taken from the Bernera crofters, and they were offered the moor between Earshader and the sea. This was not as extensive an area and although the crofters were not satisfied, they agreed to accept the offer - indeed they could do little else in those days. They also had to agree to build a dyke (turf wall) of seven miles at their own expense between Scaliscro and the new grazing. The crofters signed or put their mark on papers to this effect read out to them by the Ground Officer, James Macrae. This stated that the Bernera men would have the right to the new ground at Earshader as long as they paid their rents and behaved in a lawful manner.

After only eighteen months, the Ground Officer returned to Bernera to inform the crofters that

they were to lose the new moor, and be given Hacklete farm in Bernera instead. The crofters were angry with this; Hacklete, although fertile, was a much smaller area and would not support their grazing needs. They had fulfilled their part of the bargain, paying their rents and building the boundary dykes. Although they were warned that refusal would mean eviction they refused to agree to the terms.



On March 4th 1874, three men arrived by boat in Kirkibost. They were James Macrae, Colin Maclellan, a Sheriff Officer, and Excise man Peter Bain. They carried with them 57 notices of eviction. These were delivered in Breacleite, Bosta and most of Tobson. As they made their way

to Hacklete farm, where they were to spend the night, they realised that they were being followed by a group of young people who apparently threw clods of earth and small stones at them. On reaching the farmhouse Colin Maclellan turned to the pursuers and said "If I had my gun with me there would be mothers mourning in Bernera tonight"

The next morning they returned to Tobson to deliver the last of the summons, and repeated this threat. While returning to their boat they were surrounded by a group of men, in an angry mood, demanding an explanation. A scuffle broke out and the Officer's oilskin was torn.

Shortly after this Angus Macdonald, one of the Bernera men involved in the disturbance, was in Stornoway on business. He was recognised and police were called to arrest him. He was a strong fellow and his resistance attracted a large crowd. Fearing general disorder, the Riot Act was read, and Angus was taken off to prison.

Colin Halliday
Kirkibost



THE GAELIC CRISIS IN THE VERNACULAR COMMUNITY

This was a report published in July by researchers from the University of the Highlands and Islands Language Sciences Institute and Soillse, a multi-institutional research collaboration.

The report, which studied the use of the language in the Western Isles, Skye and Tiree, said that if trends continue Gaelic-speaking communities could vanish within the next 10 years.

Falling numbers of speakers, lack of everyday use of the language among family and friends and indifference among young people are all helping the decline, the research said.

All of the Bernera News team have been trying to learn some basic Gaelic recently, thanks in a large part to Anna MacKinnon, teacher of the Uig Learners Gaelic classes. We have been thinking for a while about including Gaelic

within the Bernera News, and how we might be able to do this. Unfortunately none of us are yet anywhere near competent enough to consider doing so, but we did wonder if anyone within our local community might be willing to help? If you wouldn't mind either writing a short piece in gaelic from time to time, or perhaps including some useful Gaelic phrases for those not familiar with the language to try learning, please do get in touch with us.

HOME SCHOOLING

A word that perhaps we knew but had not experienced personally is the word 'home schooling'.

Along with many parents across our islands, and across the United Kingdom and many parts of our world, no longer is this word a theoretical description but an extremely practical and present reality. Requiring not only young children to be educated but also for their parent(s) and / or guardian(s) to rapidly increase their own knowledge. Challenging, novel, interesting and yes educational for both parties.



Recently, during the festive period after tea-time one night we went out for an evening stroll. And as we looked up we immediately became aware of how insignificant we really were in the greater scheme of things. Above us and all around us we saw the fulfilment of what the reformer John Calvin noted all those hundreds of years ago that creation is the amphitheatre of God's glory.

Against the backdrop of the heavens and the earth, God projects his inherent beauty, majesty, and glory. Little wonder that the psalmist in his own day declared, *'What is man that You are mindful of him, And the son of man that You visit him?'* **Psalms 8:4**

At that very moment something which I heard on CBeebies came to mind. That there are more stars in the sky than there are grains of sand on the earth. Quite an incredible fact when one considers

how small a grain of sand is and then one considers how many grains of sand there are even in one square metre of beach at Bosta.

Yet, more surprisingly still is the fact that God has made humanity the crown over the whole of His creation. Giving us authority, dominion, and yes, responsibility over this vast world into which He has placed us.

A world that may continue in existence long after we have gone. Gone where? You might ask. A good question!

Well, for the person who places their faith and trust in Jesus it ends in a place that far surpasses the biggest mansions in Belgravia and the most opulent Palaces of this world's richest royal families. A destination that fulfils the promise Jesus gave to His followers before He left this world – *'In My Father's house are many mansions; if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you. And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and receive you to Myself; that where I am, there you may be also'*.

May this be the reality in your and my life also as we continue to travel through this New Year of 2021.

Rev Hugh Maurice Stewart
Uig & Bernera



BERNERA BUY, SELL, SWAP

We have been asked to include a small section within the Bernera News where people can advertise things for sale, to give away, or wanted in our local community. To include an advert please send us an email to **hello@thedailyceilidh.co.uk** or ring us on **01851 600159**, and make sure you include contact details that you don't mind being published for anyone to get in touch.

Bookcases - Peter at The Old Manse is looking for bookcases. If you have any looking for a new home please get in touch with Peter or Callum Macaulay.